

Relationship Dynamics Analysis Paper

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CMM 320: Interpersonal Communication

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April 13, 2026

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After reflecting on my relationship with my sister Maddy throughout this semester, it has become clear that we are very close. While we are best friends, the transitions in our 20s have significantly changed how we connect. Since she now lives in Columbus and I will be a senior at UD next year, the physical distance often makes it feel like we're drifting apart, and our connection is becoming weaker. My previous two papers have focused on the basics of our communication, such as active listening in perception checking. But after reviewing chapters 9-13 of our textbook and delving deeper into our relationship dynamics, I can see specific patterns that explain why we stay close in some areas and where we still have room to grow. By looking more into our **relational maintenance**, **social support**, and **interpersonal attraction**, as well as analyzing **relational dialectics**, **communication climate**, and **conflict management**, I aim to ensure that our bond stays strong even amid our busy, demanding lives and schedules now.

One of the biggest strengths Maddy and I have that keeps us connected is our commitment to **relational maintenance** and the actions we take every day to keep our relationship functioning well. Because she lives in Columbus and is busy with her career and public health, and I live at UD in Dayton, Ohio, we must stay vigilant in staying connected. Our weekly FaceTime calls serve as a form of **assurance**, letting each other know the relationship is a priority. Also, shopping together online is a way to **share tasks**, even from a distance, which helps us maintain our bond. After everything I've learned this semester, I've noticed that when I am the first one to reach out during a busy week at Starbucks and after a long day of classes, it reinforces the idea that she is important to me and that I want to make her a priority.

Maintenance requires a lot of work, and I have to stay disciplined about making time for these calls so that we don't become strangers to one another.

My relationship with Maddy has built a strong foundation on **interpersonal attraction**, specifically **social attraction**, because we truly enjoy each other's company and are always trying to make each other feel better and laugh. Certain humor is a very important major strength in our relationship because it makes our interactions more rewarding and motivates us to put even just a little bit more effort. This leads directly into our high level of **social support**. Maddy is the first person I turn to when I'm stressed about my 18-credit class load, plus the 30 hours a week I manage at Starbucks. While there are three types of social support: emotional, informational, and instrumental, Maddy primarily provides me with **emotional support**. She listens to my venting about my 30-hour work week at Starbucks, which helps me manage my stress. Ahmad and Chowdhury (2022) argue that "the quality of our lives is more determined by the quality of our interpersonal relationships; individuals with better connections have a greater overall life" (p. 20). The social attraction is the glue that makes maintaining our relationship feel normal and natural. Even if we go a few days without talking or checking in, having that attraction remains, and we pick up right where we left off, no matter what.

Even with all these strengths, Maddy and I still face challenges in our relationship. Specifically, **relational dialectics** is our biggest issue. We tend to struggle with the dialectic of connection versus autonomy. As we get older and try to build our own lives, I often lose our connection to each other. When she is busy with her own social life in Columbus, a lot is happening. I feel more demanding of her time, which can sometimes lead to my feelings of resentment or unhappiness. For me not to feel this way and to prove I need to accept that my need for autonomy isn't a rejection of our relationship. I will be able to work more on this by being supportive of her goals and recognizing that our connection isn't and doesn't require us to be close all the time. Anyone understands that this tension is a natural part of all relationships,

which personally allows me to focus more on my academic and social life here in Dayton and at UD.

Communication climate is another area that Maddy and I need to work on. Well, our climate is positive. It can be **disconfirming** at times when we fall into a habit of impersonal responses. When we stick to that surface-level of communication, like just asking how work is or how your day is, it feels more like a routine checkup than an actual connection. This simple small talk acts as an easy way out when we are tired or don't feel like having a big conversation. It works, but it doesn't help or improve the relationship at all. To improve this, I want to be more deliberate with my verbal communication rather than using a basic everyday script. I want to share my feelings and the challenges I'm facing in my life and create a deeper connection with Maddy. Being able to send more **confirming messages** acknowledging her experiences and feelings as a person is a very positive change in our relationship. Still, it requires me to be the first to go deeper in our conversations and set that pattern.

Lastly, our **conflict management** needs to be more proactive. We have never had a real fight, but after this class, I have noticed that maybe that isn't always a good thing. That is more of a defensive response when something is bothering us. We are more likely to avoid it than risk an argument. For example, when she hasn't called or reached out all week, I tend to keep it to myself and bring it up to her later. This, in turn, creates internal distance.

According to Ahmad and Chowdhury (2022), effective communication is "linearly related to quality decision-making and relationship health" (p. 21). This research highlights that the success of my bond with Maddy depends directly on how we handle our interactions. Because our relationship health is so closely tied to this communication quality, I must change my personal conflict style to ensure we stay connected. Specifically, I need to move away from

my habit of avoidance and towards a collaborative style. To improve this, I can start using my "I" statements, like saying, "I have missed talking to her, and can we maybe find a time this weekend to catch up?" By taking this approach, we can solve the problem together rather than me just ignoring it and letting the frustration and annoyance build, potentially damaging our relationship in the long term.

After this semester, learning about all these dynamics and how reaching them has helped me see that a strong, stable relationship with Maddy doesn't just happen; it is something we must work on and actively build every day and chance we get. We had strong interpersonal attraction and provided each other with great social support. Still, we need to focus more on the tensions of relational dialectics as we grow older, and more of our lives might interfere with our connection.

By focusing more on relational maintenance and creating a better interpersonal **communication climate**, I can ensure that you don't just stay in touch from time to time, but that you build a growing closeness as siblings and friends. I am unable to control how busy Maddy's life is or what she has going on, but I can control how conversations impact our relationship and our lives. This project this semester has not only taught me more about how we act around people, communicate, and create relationships with others, but has also given me the tools to better my relationship with my best friend and sister.

References

- Adler, R. B., & Proctor, R. F. (2024). *Interplay: The process of interpersonal communication* (16th ed.). Oxford University Press.
- Ahmad, A., & Chowdhury, D. (2022). A review of effective communication and its impact on interpersonal relationships, conflict resolution, and decision-making. *Review of Applied Socio-Economic Research*, 24(2), 18-23. <https://doi.org/10.54609/reaser.v24i2.281>